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Teaching Statement

Educators are often asked why they went into the field, and, *truthfully*, I hate it. The short, cynical reality is that the world left me with no other choice. The longer, more honest answer looks around at a crumbling, flatlining institution kept on life support thanks primarily to the efforts of the very same folks being put on trial. I became an educator despite what everyone else said. *Those who can't do, teach. Whatever you do, do not become a teacher. Anyone can teach; you are meant for so much more.* Maybe some of what they say is true. Maybe this applies to somebody somewhere. But not to me.

I have the privilege of teaching English and Media Studies at the secondary level because I believe that stories – and the questions we ask about *how* and *why* they are told – are among the most powerful tools available for developing critical thinkers. I, too, believe we are in the business of nurturing and bolstering young minds. In my single year teaching at South Miami Senior High, I have come to understand that the most durable learning happens not when students master a set of skills, but when they discover that those skills unlock something in the world they already inhabit. My philosophy is designed around that discovery.

My teachings center on a deceptively simple premise: students read more carefully when they care about what they are reading, and they write more honestly when they have genuine stakes in the argument. I have also come to realize that they will try more when they care *who* they are reading and writing for. In practice, this means two things: building courses from texts and media students already encounter – and asking harder questions about them – and perhaps the more challenging demand of the two, being authentically myself. As educators, we are performers. If there are students in the classroom, we are “on” – ready for that unexpected conversation, for that question we have already answered, or for unacceptable behavior we must address. Part of what we are asking our students is to reveal bits and pieces of themselves to us, and for them to feel comfortable and confident doing so, I firmly believe we must model it first. *An unsurprising realization for most teachers, I am sure.* Easier said than done, though.

Once the students buy into you as their instructor, the rest becomes a whole lot easier. The shift from passive consumer to critical reader is rarely dramatic. In fact, it's usually quiet. But it happens, and it becomes apparent to me. My job is to create the conditions for that moment.

This approach extends directly into my graduate work in Writing and Rhetoric at UCF, where I had the opportunity to design a college-level composition course built around literary and screen adaptation. The course, *Translations From Page to Screen: The Art of Adaptation*, uses the relationship between written texts and their screen adaptations as both the subject of inquiry and the vehicle for teaching academic writing. Its signature assignment, Staging the Page: The Adaptation Project, offers students two paths: an analytical essay arguing for the significance of specific adaptation choices in relation to a specific text, or a creative adaptation accompanied by a rigorous critical reflection. That choice matters. When students select their own text and their own mode of inquiry, the resulting work is almost always more honest and more precise than

anything a uniform assignment would produce. Offering genuine choice is not a pedagogical accommodation – it is a theory of motivation made concrete, and it remains a fundamental cornerstone in my instructional philosophy.

The digital humanities dimension of my practice is not a layer added on top of my teaching; it is embedded in the questions I ask students to bring to any text, written or visual. When my Media Studies students analyze a film poster, a streaming interface, or a marketing campaign, they are already doing digital humanities work – examining *how* form shapes meaning, *how* platforms condition reception, *how* authorship is distributed and contested. At the college level, this means designing courses where the tools of media and literary analysis are brought into genuine conversation rather than separated into disciplinary silos. Despite recent embracing of interdisciplinary work, particularly in the fields of film and literature, I am aware this type of study is sometimes positioned as a departure from traditional English instruction. I think of it as its fullest expression. Some of the most important questions about any text – who made this, for whom, and to what end – do not respect departmental boundaries, and neither should the methods we teach students to answer them.

My approach to artificial intelligence in the classroom emerged firsthand from experimentation rather than institutional policy. I used AI tools to perform the same kinds of textual and visual analysis I would eventually ask my students to perform – comparing corresponding scenes across Ted Chiang’s novella “Story of Your Life” and the *Arrival* screenplay, analyzing book covers as visual rhetoric, generating them and evaluating possible adaptation approaches for a chosen source text. These exercises produced something more valuable than efficiency: a clear and concrete picture of what AI can and cannot do as a reader. AI notices patterns quickly, generates plausible-sounding interpretations, and sustains confident prose even when its analysis is thin. The *worst* human readers can do something AI cannot: they can sit with ambiguity, bring cultural and emotional attunement, and resist the pressure to resolve what should remain unresolved. Imagine what the best readers can do. My course policy reflects this distinction directly. Students are invited to use AI as a thinking partner and planning aid, and they are required to document that use in specificity – naming not only what the tool contributed but where it felt short and what their own analysis added. The goal is not compliance with a policy but the development of a literacy, one that treats AI as an object of study rather than an authority.

I yearn to teach courses where the questions students bring with them on the first day – about the stories they love, the media they consume, and the world they are inheriting – are taken seriously as a starting point of academic work. The courses I have taught, and the courses I have designed and hope to design, are built on the conviction that rigor and genuine engagement are not in tension. My most intellectually demanding assignments have also been my most enjoyable ones to read. That is not a coincidence. It is what happens when students believe in themselves, when they believe in what they are saying, when they believe they are being seen.

Thank you for your consideration.